

Consumer Sentiment & Behavioral Analysis of AI-Driven Social Media Recommendations

Submitted by

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Research Domain: AI in Consumer Behavior, Marketing & Digital Ecosystems
May 2026

Python · Pandas · TextBlob · Matplotlib · Seaborn · Jupyter Notebook

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This project investigates how AI-driven recommendation systems influence consumer sentiment, behavioral patterns, and lifestyle perceptions across social media platforms. Using a dataset of approximately 715 consumer reviews and social media responses, sentiment analysis was conducted using TextBlob, supplemented by keyword frequency analysis and data visualization through Matplotlib and Seaborn.

The analysis reveals that the majority of consumer sentiment sits in the neutral-to-positive range, with Instagram emerging as the platform generating the strongest engagement. Keyword analysis identifies 'ads,' 'content,' and 'trust' as the most recurrently discussed themes, underscoring the dual dynamic of commercial engagement and growing consumer wariness. The project surfaces meaningful behavioral and ethical considerations around algorithmic personalization that are relevant to both digital marketing practice and consumer psychology research.

PROJECT OVERVIEW

Social media platforms are not neutral environments. Recommendation algorithms decide what users see, how often they see it, and in what sequence — and those decisions have measurable effects on what people want, trust, and aspire to. This project began from that observation: that the connection between algorithmic curation and consumer psychology is worth examining not just conceptually, but through actual behavioral data.

The analysis focuses on understanding how AI-driven recommendation ecosystems shape consumer sentiment and engagement across platforms including Instagram, Facebook, and Twitter. By combining sentiment classification with keyword frequency analysis and word cloud visualization, the project builds a layered picture of how consumers experience and respond to personalized digital environments.

OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY

- ▶ Analyze consumer sentiment distribution across AI-driven social media recommendation contexts.
- ▶ Identify platform-specific sentiment patterns and differences in consumer response.
- ▶ Surface frequently recurring themes in consumer discourse — including trust, privacy, ads, and lifestyle influence.

- ▶ Interpret the behavioral and psychological implications of algorithmic personalization on consumer perception.
- ▶ Explore the ethical dimensions of AI-driven content curation, particularly around transparency and consumer autonomy.

DATASET DESCRIPTION

The dataset (sentimentdataset.csv) contains approximately 715 consumer-generated text entries sourced from social media platforms — primarily Instagram, Facebook, and Twitter. Each entry includes the original review or comment text, the associated platform, and additional metadata enabling behavioral segmentation.

The dataset was preprocessed to remove noise, normalize text formatting, and prepare entries for sentiment classification. TextBlob's polarity scoring was applied to classify each entry as Positive, Negative, or Neutral based on the emotional valence of the language used. The resulting labelled dataset formed the basis for all subsequent analysis and visualization.

METHODOLOGY

The analytical pipeline was built entirely in Python, executed within a Jupyter Notebook environment. The process followed six broad stages:

- ▶ **Data Preprocessing:** Raw text entries were cleaned, lowercased, and stripped of irrelevant characters to ensure consistency before analysis.
- ▶ **Sentiment Classification:** TextBlob's polarity scoring was used to assign each entry a sentiment label — Positive (polarity > 0), Negative (polarity < 0), or Neutral (polarity = 0).
- ▶ **Keyword Frequency Analysis:** A curated set of behaviorally relevant keywords (including 'trust,' 'ads,' 'algorithm,' 'privacy,' 'content,' and 'lifestyle') was used to measure how frequently these themes appeared across the dataset.
- ▶ **Word Cloud Visualization:** A word cloud was generated from the full text corpus to surface dominant consumer vocabulary and discussion themes organically.
- ▶ **Platform-wise Analysis:** Sentiment distributions were segmented by platform to identify whether consumer experience differed meaningfully across Instagram, Facebook, and Twitter.
- ▶ **Visualization & Interpretation:** All findings were visualized using Matplotlib and Seaborn, with emphasis on behavioral and business-relevant interpretation rather than purely technical output.

VISUAL ANALYSIS

1. Distribution of Consumer Sentiment

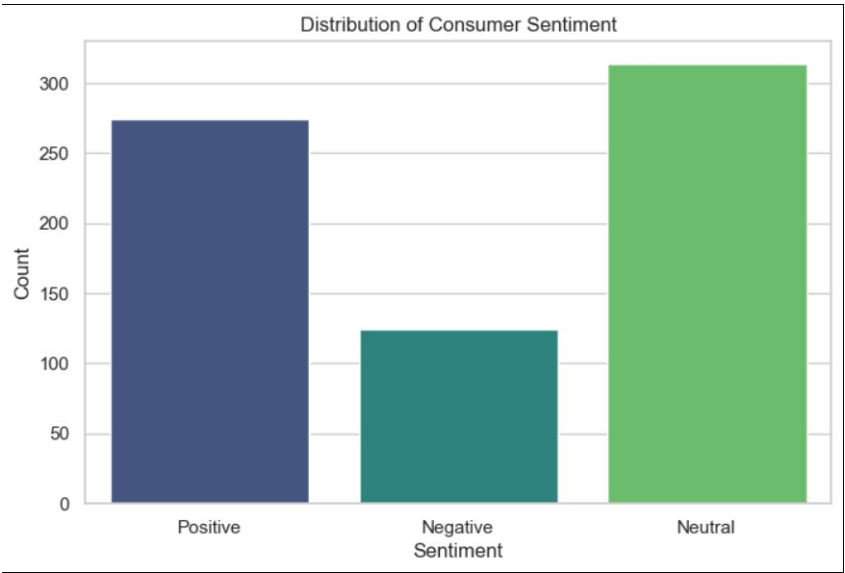


Figure: Distribution of Consumer Sentiment — Positive, Negative, Neutral

Interpretation: Of the ~715 entries analysed, approximately 315 were classified as Neutral, 275 as Positive, and 125 as Negative. The dominance of neutral sentiment is significant: it suggests that a large portion of consumer expression about AI-driven recommendations is neither enthusiastic nor overtly critical — reflecting a kind of passive acceptance rather than active endorsement. The comparatively low negative count should not be read as satisfaction; it may simply indicate that most dissatisfaction is expressed subtly rather than explicitly.

2. Platform-wise Consumer Sentiment

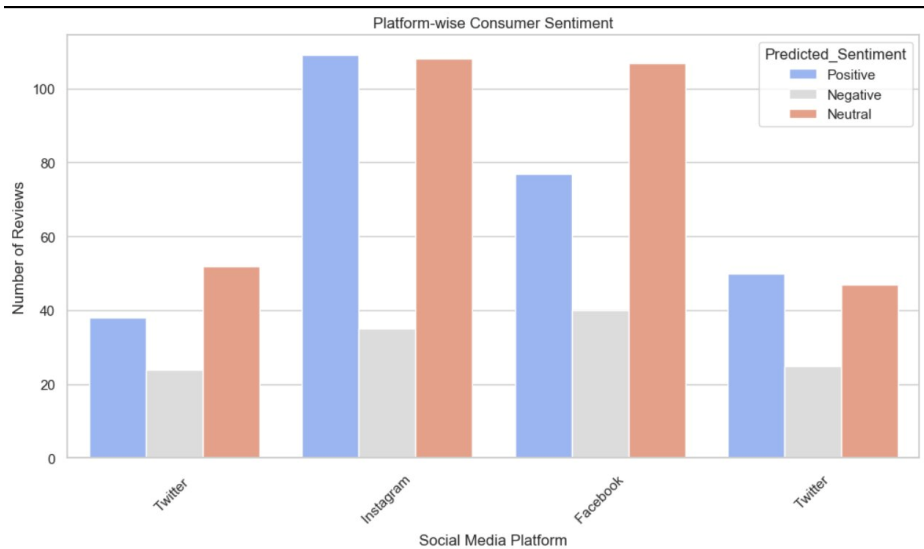


Figure: Platform-wise Consumer Sentiment — Instagram, Facebook, Twitter

Interpretation: Instagram generates by far the highest volume of both positive and neutral sentiment. This is consistent with the platform's heavily visual and aspirational content format, which tends to produce stronger emotional responses — whether admiration or passive scrolling. Facebook shows a similar positive-to-neutral ratio but at lower volume. Twitter's comparatively balanced distribution suggests a more reactive and opinion-driven user base. For marketers, Instagram's sentiment intensity makes it both the most valuable and the most ethically consequential platform for recommendation-driven influence.

3. Frequently Discussed Consumer Themes (Word Cloud)



Figure: Word Cloud — Dominant Themes in Consumer Discourse

Interpretation: The word cloud reveals that consumer discourse is heavily anchored in experiential and emotional vocabulary: 'feeling,' 'moment,' 'joy,' 'life,' 'new,' 'friend,' and 'day' dominate the canvas. This suggests that users engage with social media content primarily through an emotional register — they are not describing products or features so much as narrating experiences and aspirations. The presence of words like 'challenge,' 'loneliness,' 'despair,' and 'betrayal' alongside 'joy' and 'excitement' points to the emotionally ambivalent relationship many consumers have with their digital environments.

4. Consumer Concerns & Behavioral Keywords

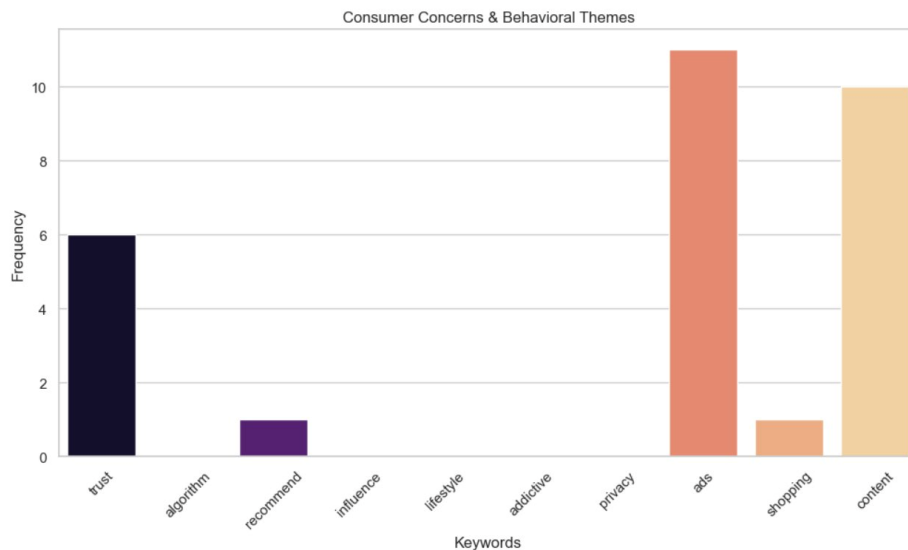


Figure: Consumer Concerns & Behavioral Themes — Keyword Frequency Analysis

Interpretation: Among the behaviorally relevant keywords tracked, 'ads' (frequency: 11) and 'content' (frequency: 10) appear most prominently, followed by 'trust' (frequency: 6). Notably, terms like 'algorithm,' 'influence,' 'privacy,' and 'lifestyle' show near-zero frequencies in explicit usage — suggesting that while consumers are affected by these forces, they do not tend to name them directly. This gap between lived experience and conscious articulation is arguably one of the most important findings: algorithmic influence appears to operate largely below the threshold of consumer awareness.

KEY BEHAVIORAL & BUSINESS INSIGHTS

- ▶ Neutral sentiment is the dominant consumer state — suggesting passive absorption rather than active engagement with recommendation-driven content. This has real implications for how brands measure 'success' in algorithm-curated environments.
- ▶ Instagram outperforms other platforms on both sentiment volume and intensity, making it the most commercially powerful — but also the most psychologically influential — platform in this dataset.
- ▶ Consumers discuss 'ads' and 'content' far more explicitly than they discuss 'algorithms' or 'privacy,' indicating that the commercial layer of recommendation systems is visible to users, but the underlying decision architecture is not.
- ▶ The emotional richness of the word cloud — spanning joy, loneliness, aspiration, and challenge — confirms that social media engagement is deeply psychological in nature. Recommendation systems are not just filtering content; they are shaping emotional experience.
- ▶ Trust appears as a recurring theme at moderate frequency, suggesting that consumers are aware of a trust relationship with platforms even if they cannot fully articulate the terms of it.

ETHICAL & PSYCHOLOGICAL OBSERVATIONS

Perhaps the most striking finding of this analysis is what consumers do not say. Words like 'algorithm,' 'influence,' and 'privacy' appear at near-zero frequencies despite being central to how these platforms operate. This absence of explicit language does not mean consumers are unaffected — quite the opposite. It suggests that the influence of recommendation systems is largely invisible to the people being influenced.

This creates an asymmetry that raises genuine ethical questions. Platforms have detailed models of user behavior and preferences; users have limited awareness of how those models shape what they see and want. The dominance of emotional vocabulary in consumer discourse — joy, aspiration, loneliness, challenge — suggests that recommendation systems are operating at a level that touches not just purchasing behavior but broader psychological experience and self-perception.

The prevalence of 'ads' and 'content' in keyword analysis also signals that consumers are beginning to notice the commercial intent embedded in their feeds, even if they lack the vocabulary to critique the mechanism itself. As this awareness grows, platforms that invest in transparency — being more open about how recommendations are generated — are likely to earn a meaningful trust advantage.

CONCLUSION

This project set out to understand how AI-driven recommendation systems influence consumer sentiment and behavioral patterns — and the data offers a clear if nuanced answer. Sentiment is predominantly neutral to positive, Instagram is the dominant platform for both engagement and influence, and the themes consumers care about most are emotional and experiential rather than explicitly analytical. Most strikingly, the forces that most powerfully shape consumer experience — algorithms, personalization, behavioral tracking — are the least explicitly discussed.

The analytical work here is a starting point rather than a conclusion. The patterns observed are meaningful enough to warrant deeper investigation: into platform-specific behavioral design, into the long-term effects of aspirational content on consumer identity, and into what ethical personalization might actually look like in practice.

FUTURE SCOPE

- ▶ Expand the dataset to include a larger and more demographically diverse sample, enabling analysis of how age, gender, and geography shape consumer response to algorithmic recommendations.
- ▶ Incorporate advanced NLP models (such as VADER or transformer-based sentiment classifiers) to capture sarcasm, mixed sentiment, and emotional nuance more precisely than polarity scoring alone.

- ▶ Conduct longitudinal analysis to understand whether consumer sentiment toward recommendation systems shifts over time — particularly as algorithmic transparency becomes a more mainstream concern.
- ▶ Explore the relationship between sentiment and specific engagement behaviors (likes, saves, purchases) to build a more complete picture of recommendation-to-action pathways.
- ▶ Examine ethical personalization frameworks and assess how design choices — such as opt-out mechanisms or transparency disclosures — affect consumer trust and platform engagement.

PROJECT RESOURCES

GitHub Repository: <https://github.com/hawxdracula/consumer-behavior-ai-analysis>

The repository contains all project materials, including the Jupyter Notebook with the full analytical pipeline, the sentimentdataset.csv dataset, project screenshots and visualizations, and this report. All resources are publicly accessible and documented for reproducibility.
